

CLOUD QUEST Andhra Pradesh CM N. Chandrababu Naidu, Union IT minister Ashwini Vaishnaw and industry leaders at the groundbreaking ceremony of Google's India AI Hub near Visakhapatnam, Apr. 28

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NAIDU BETS ON DATA CENTRES

The Andhra Pradesh CM wants to make Visakhapatnam a data centre hub, but how honest is his promise of jobs and environmental security?

By PRASAD NICHENAMETLA

Come September 2028, and Visakhapatnam in Andhra Pradesh may become home to Google's India AI Hub, a $15 billion (Rs 1.4 lakh crore) artificial intelligence and cloud infrastructure project Google subsidiary Raiden Infotech is developing in partnership with AdaniConnex and Airtel's Nxtra. Andhra Pradesh chief minister N. Chandrababu Naidu presided over its groundbreaking ceremony this April. His government has also allotted 855 acres at Bhogapuram in neighbouring Vizianagaram district to Reliance Industries for a 1.5 GW (gigawatt) data centre. Several other projects are in the pipeline, including a 500 MW facility being developed by Sify in partnership with Meta.

Nearly three decades earlier, as CM of undivided Andhra Pradesh, Naidu had transformed Hyderabad into one of India's foremost IT hubs, earning it the moniker, Cyberabad. In one of the defining moments of that journey, he had persuaded Bill Gates to establish the Microsoft India Development Center there. Having lost that growth engine to Telangana, Naidu is now trying to script a similar transformation for Visakhapatnam by positioning it as a hub for hyperscale data centres.

Factories of the digital economy, data centres house thousands of servers that store, process and transmit the information powering everything from digital payments and video streaming to e-commerce and cloud computing. As AI models become larger, governments and firms worldwide are racing to build facilities capable of handling unprecedented volumes of data and computing power.

The Google-led project is only the beginning. Back in October when the tech behemoth had an-